

Resistance in Mahasweta Devi's 'Draupadi'.

Mahasweta Devi's *Draupadi*, a poignant short story written in Bengali — presents an important case study of resisting, gender and independence, specially through its protagonist Dopdi Mejhen, whose identity is made up of being both an Adivasi (indigenous) woman and Naxalite revolutionary. Devi, India's most admired writer and social activist, wrote about the different marginalized communities in India and criticized that effect of exploitation of Adivasis and lower-caste people in India. Devi that she was a political prisoner, while in the condition of Dopdi; as when Dopdi scrutinizes the intersectionality of oppression — gender, class, caste and ethnicity to bring down state-inflicted violence and societal norms on one hand, so *Draupadi* cannot be studied without placing it under such scrutiny. Dopdi has many layers which evolve as the narrative weaves through her struggle against the forces that oppress and dominate her, marking the changes in female empowerment within a repressive political atmosphere. *Draupadi* is the embodiment of such resistance, that Dopdi, following her conviction never to be victimised again reclaims her identity and overcomes with this act of defiance both patriarchy and colonialism.

Dehumanization persists even after Dopdi is taken captive. Once taken, she needs to be 'opposed,' belittled and treated as less than human, where 'your hands are bound behind you...every bone is broken, your body is a horrifying injury.' In a bid to make her talk and reveal her allies, Dopdi is sexually assaulted several times by the local officials. While she is being assaulted, Dopdi remains silent, feeling shame as a 'tear rolls down from the edge of her eye'. Once the men depart, Devi changes the viewpoint to Dopdi's perspective as she reflects on the consequences of the violence inflicted upon her body. Words cannot truly express the terror of what Dopdi has experienced. Devi forces us to face the harsh truth by graphically describing the condition of Dopdi's body post-attack—'her breasts are chewed raw, the nipples ripped,' 'her vagina is haemorrhaging,' and her 'thigh and pubic hair saturated

with dried blood.' In this tale, Mahasweta Devi instils Dopdi's body with the history and narrative that the officers' eyes aim to obliterate. Dopdi's decision not to react or answer to the violence directed at her is a strong act of defiance. Devi's raw language powerfully illustrates the violence the State enacts on Dopdi, seeking to change her from a resistant individual into an obedient one. Nonetheless, through the same unrefined language, Devi similarly portrays Dopdi's defiance and rebellion, especially as a tribal woman engaged in the Naxalite movement.

The selection of the name Draupadi for Mahasweta Devi's character Dopdi Mehjen is rich with deep symbolism and intertextual connections as both the figures exhibit a strong resistance to patriarchal domination. Draupadi, a character from the Mahabharata, represents resilience, enduring the disgrace of being stripped in a royal court while preserving her dignity and strength. In the same way, Dopdi endures intense violence and loss of humanity from state authorities. Nonetheless, whereas Draupadi in the epic depends on divine aid for her salvation, Dopdi's resilience is grounded in her own rebellious determination. In contrast to Draupadi from the Mahabharata, who holds the title of queen, Dopdi is a tribal woman who faces marginalization due to both her gender and her socio-economic background. Her defiance is directed not only at personal degradation but also at institutional oppression and exploitation. Devi's Dopdi turns her body into a symbol of defiance; she faces her captors with her exposed, battered form, rejecting shame, and compelling them to face the brutality of their deeds. This act of rebellion marks a significant break from Draupadi's call for divine justice, representing a bold and unrefined expression of self-empowerment and political resistance. By contrasting these two characters, Devi emphasizes the continuous battle against patriarchal standards while questioning conventional stories of female victimization

and defiance. Essentially, whereas Draupadi from the Mahabharata is celebrated for her demand for justice, Dopdi Mehjen is enshrined for her unwavering, fierce resistance.

However, compared to Mahasweta Devi's other writings, "Draupadi" is distinguished by its catching story of defiance against the harsh conditions endured by marginalized groups. For example, in "The Breast Giver," Devi narrates the tale of 'Jashoda', a woman who serves as a wet nurse to support her family, only to be cast aside when she is deemed no longer necessary. This narrative, similar to "Draupadi," investigates the misuse of a woman's body, yet within a distinct framework of economic and societal commodification. Likewise, "Rudali" tells the tale of 'Sanichari', a destitute woman who takes on the role of a professional mourner, transforming her sorrow into a way to survive. Both narratives showcase the resilience and strength of women confronting oppressive societal systems, similar to the protagonist in "Draupadi," who confronts her oppressors with an act of profound defiance. These parallels emphasize "Draupadi" as not only a crucial story of resistance in Indian literature but also as a component of a wider global discourse that tackles social injustice, resilience, and the struggle for dignity. By positioning "Draupadi" next to these influential pieces, we can recognize its significant influence and lasting importance in literature.

Mahasweta Devi's Draupadi remains a powerful narrative of resistance, portraying Dopdi Mehjen's refusal to submit to oppression as a redefinition of both victimhood and agency. Through Dopdi, Devi presents a radical critique of the intersections between gender, caste, and state violence, highlighting the resilience of marginalized communities. Dopdi's defiance, both physical and psychological, exemplifies the complexity of resistance and asserts the importance of self-definition in a world structured by power dynamics. Draupadi

serves not only as a story of resilience but also as a critique of the systemic forces that oppress indigenous women, positioning Dopdi as a symbol of enduring strength and autonomy. In the end, Devi's Draupadi is a timeless reminder of the power of defiance, providing readers with an unflinching portrayal of human resilience in the face of dehumanization. In "Draupadi," Devi highlighted the lasting strength of resistance, even in the darkest moments.

WORK CITED LIST

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